Entente, 1949–1958

In 1947, India was determined to be non-aligned between the US and USSR in the emerging Cold War. It admired both societies for different reasons and wanted good relations with the two superpowers even as it was wary of them. With the civil war behind it, communist China was closer to the USSR and suspicious of the US. By the mid-1950s, India and China were closer to the USSR and convergent in their worries about the US.

Non-aligned India Between the US and the USSR

Delhi's relations with Washington immediately after independence were complicated by differences over Pakistan, India's perceptions of the Cold War, and US views of non-alignment. Delhi was convinced that the US had followed the UK's lead in favouring the Pakistani position on Kashmir. Cold War considerations rather than the merit of India's and Pakistan's respective arguments on Kashmiri accession had determined the Anglo-American position. This reinforced India's worry that the Anglo-American powers had an overly alarmist view of communism and were pursuing the wrong strategy in dealing with it. Another global war might result from their ill-judged policies, resulting in the use of nuclear weapons, with disastrous consequences for the world at large. Nehru insisted that India wanted to be friends with everyone and did reach out to Washington for diplomatic, military, and economic reasons, but he also deplored Washington's Manichean view of international politics and its ridiculing of non-alignment.

By 1950, whatever its view of non-alignment, the US was increasingly worried that India would tilt towards the Soviets or even go communist. Even though Nehru had his own brand of anti-communism and had assured the US that India would side with the Anglo-American powers in a 'third world war', Washington was afraid that Delhi would eventually align with the Soviets. Worse, if India failed to deliver on economic development,